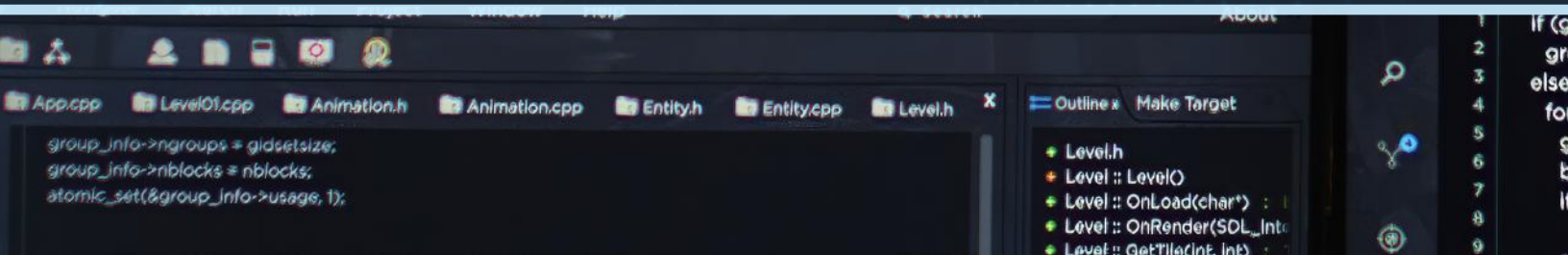


Smart Licensing with Cisco

This guide gives Dell engineers a straightforward introduction to Cisco Smart Licensing. It walks through how Smart Licensing Using Policy (SLP) works, how to set up Smart Accounts and Virtual Accounts, and how to register devices in Cisco License Central. Use it as a quick reference to keep deployments simple, compliant, and efficient.

Select one of the tabs or turn the page to get started!



Welcome to Your Smart Licensing Experience

As a leading Cisco partner, Dell is committed to delivering streamlined, secure, and scalable technology solutions to customers around the globe. Cisco Smart Licensing helps us do just that—by providing a modern, flexible approach to software license management that aligns with Dell’s operational excellence and enterprise service model.

This guide is your starting point for understanding how Smart Licensing supports Dell’s business priorities, including:

- **Greater Visibility:** Monitor license usage across your customer base in real time.
- **Operational Simplicity:** Centralized Smart Accounts and Virtual Accounts make license management seamless.
- **Enterprise Agility:** Easily transfer licenses across environments, teams, or use cases as business needs evolve.

As part of Dell’s technical ecosystem, you’ll gain access to powerful Cisco resources—from self-service portals to direct high-touch engagement options—ensuring your teams and your customers always have the tools they need.

What You’ll Learn

- How Smart Licensing works
- Tools to manage and monitor usage
- Where to go for help

What You’ll Use

- Licensing Support Site (24/7 access)
- Licensing Hub & Video Channel
- Ask Licensing Chat

What to Expect

- Fast answers to your questions
- Guidance for advanced licensing topics
- Easy navigation and quick links

Smarter Software Licensing for Dell's Connected Ecosystem

Cisco Smart Licensing is a flexible, cloud-based software license model that simplifies how customers activate and manage their Cisco software. It replaces legacy licensing mechanisms that relied on Product Activation Keys (PAKs) and manual tracking.

How it Works

- Devices register with Cisco Smart Software Manager (CSSM).
- The device shares entitlement and usage data.
- CSSM tracks entitlements and provides acknowledgment (ACK) files.
- For offline environments, usage is manually exported and uploaded for tracking.

Smart Licensing supports a range of deployment models: connected, mediated (through tools like CSLU or SSM On-Prem), or fully air-gapped. It is mandatory for Cisco platforms such as the MDS 9000 running NX-OS 9.x or higher.

Key Smart Licensing Tools

Tool	Function
CSSM (Cisco Smart Software Manager)	Central web portal for Smart License registration and management
CSLU (Cisco Smart Licensing Utility)	Windows-based proxy between devices and CSSM
SSM On-Prem	For fully disconnected or secure environments (air-gapped licensing)



Did You Know:

Dell teams can manage multiple customer environments under a single Smart Account hierarchy—making it easier to provide proactive support, licensing guidance, and renewal forecasting.

[Click here to view our Smart Licensing Guide](#)

Before You Begin: Setting Up Your Cisco Smart Account

Before using Cisco Smart Licensing, customers must have a Cisco Smart Account. This is where all software entitlements and licenses are stored and managed. The Smart Account acts as the central repository for license tracking, assignment, and reporting across the organization.

Smart Account Setup Overview:



Step 1: Create or Access a Cisco Smart Account

Visit Cisco Software Central > Click Request a Smart Account.

Requires a valid CCOID (Cisco.com ID).

If you're a partner, you can request access to a customer's Smart Account (pending approval by the customer admin).

Step 2: Activate Virtual Accounts (Optional)

Within a Smart Account, create Virtual Accounts (VAs) to segment licenses by project, location, or business unit.



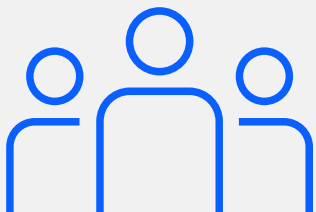
Step 3: Assign Roles

Role-based access ensures control over who can:

- View licenses (Viewer)
- Manage licenses (User)
- Add users or change settings (Admin)

Role types include:

- Smart Account Admin/User/Viewer
- Virtual Account Admin/User/Viewer



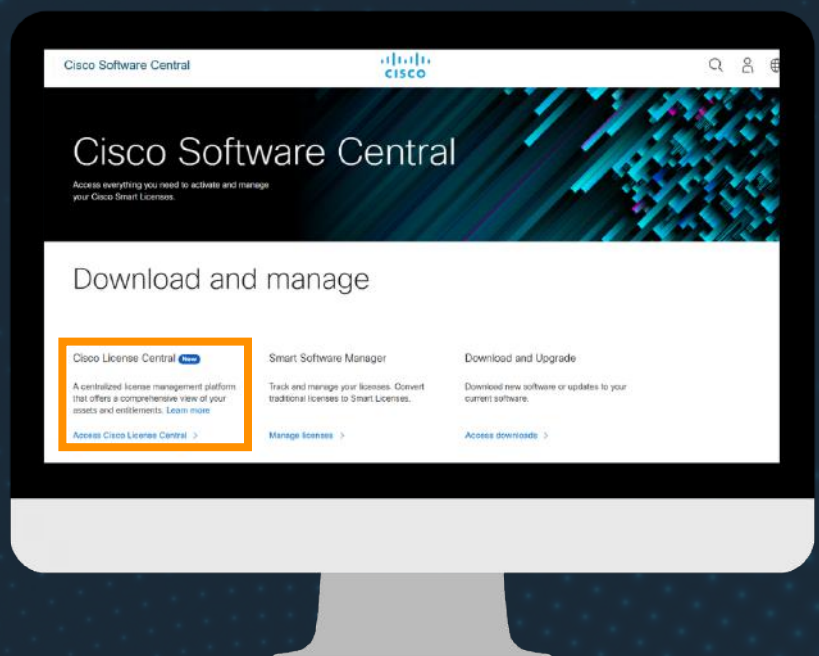
Accessing Cisco License Central

Cisco License Central is Cisco's next-gen license management interface:

- Streamlined compared to legacy tools like MCE (My Cisco Entitlements)
- Provides a single view of all licenses, orders, and device entitlements
- Improved self-service, intuitive filters, alerts, and usage insights

To access:

- Go to [Cisco Software Central](#)
- Click Cisco License Central
- Sign in with your CCOID
- Select or request access to your Smart Account



CCOID Requirements

You need a valid Cisco.com ID (CCOID) to:

- Log into Cisco License Central
- Request Smart Account access
- View e-delivery orders
- Manage licenses

If your email does not match the domain of an existing Smart Account, you'll be limited to accessing e-delivery order details unless granted access by an administrator.

Need help creating a CCOID? [Click here](#) for a tutorial.

[Click here to view our Smart Licensing Guide](#)

How to Access Cisco License Central

Cisco License Central is the gateway for managing Smart Accounts, Virtual Accounts, and license entitlements. Once you log in with your CCOID, you can view orders, assign roles, and validate license usage across customer environments.

Users with Access to a Smart Account

Users with access to a single

Smart Account: Login to the portal and continue

Users with access to multiple

Smart Accounts: Login to the portal, select a Smart Account and continue



User Roles	
Smart Account Admin	Virtual Account Admin
Smart Account User	Virtual Account User
Smart Account Viewer	Virtual Account Viewer

Users whose email does not match an existing Smart Account domain

Users whose email does not match an existing Smart Account domain:

If you have an e-delivery order notification email:

1. Proceed to the Cisco License Central portal without a Smart Account or
2. Create a new Smart Account or Request access to a Smart Account and then login to the Cisco License Central

1. Smart Account roles, their access levels and functionalities in Cisco License Central are similar to that of MCE. You can have access to one or more Smart Accounts.
2. Proceeding without a Smart Account will allow users to only access the e-delivery orders in the “Orders” tab of Cisco License Central.

A photograph of three people, two men and one woman, looking at a tablet. The man in the center is pointing at the screen. The woman on the left is holding the tablet. The man on the right is looking at the screen. They are all smiling and appear to be in a collaborative work environment.

Cisco License Central is our next generation platform designed to simplify license management for our partners and customers.

After You Access Cisco License Central (CLC): What to Do Next

Before you can troubleshoot, move licenses, or register new hardware, you need a clear, accurate picture of the customer's current licensing landscape. Cisco License Central (CLC) is the single source of truth for:



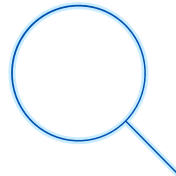
Devices

Which devices are registered and whether they are in compliance or overdue for reporting.



Licenses

What licenses are available or in use and if the right features are allocated where they're needed.



Assets

Where each asset "lives" – the Smart Account and Virtual Account that determine visibility, entitlement pools, and who can manage them.



Click on the information icon to view screenshots of where to find these.

For Dell engineers, this visibility is critical to:

- Quickly **validate** if a customer's reported issue is account-related or device-side.
- **Identify** mismatches between entitlements and usage before they cause compliance flags.
- **Pinpoint** which account admin or support channel to engage for the fastest resolution.



Starting every engagement with this view ensures you're working from accurate data, not assumptions—saving time, avoiding repeated escalations, and helping the customer get back to business faster.

Register Assets with Cisco: Choosing a Transport

Once you've set up a Smart Account and accessed Cisco License Central, the next step is registering assets. Registration links devices to Cisco Smart Software Manager (CSSM) so license usage can be tracked and acknowledged.

Think of this step as: *"How will my device talk to Cisco?"*

There are three supported transport paths:

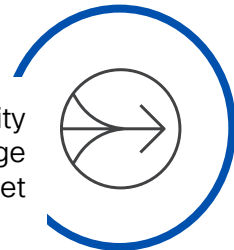


1. Direct Cloud Connection

Device connects to CSSM over HTTPS | Reporting and acknowledgment files are exchanged automatically | Easiest option when the environment allows outbound HTTPS

2. Mediated Connection (CSLU or SSM On-Prem)

Device connects to a local collector (Cisco Smart Licensing Utility or Smart Software Manager On-Prem) | The collector syncs usage data with CSSM | Ideal for secure networks where direct internet access is restricted but local mediation is allowed



3. Offline / Air-Gapped

No connectivity between device and CSSM | Device generates usage reports (RUM files) which are manually uploaded to CSSM | Acknowledgment (ACK) files are downloaded from CSSM and manually installed on the device | Required in environments with strict isolation policies.

Why this Choice Matters

- **Determines** whether reporting/ACKs are automatic or manual.
- **Impacts** which CLI commands you configure (transport smart, transport cslu, or transport off).
- **Dictates** the operational overhead: automated sync vs. manual file transfer.

Tip for Dell Engineers

Always confirm network restrictions before registering devices. If HTTPS is blocked, ask:

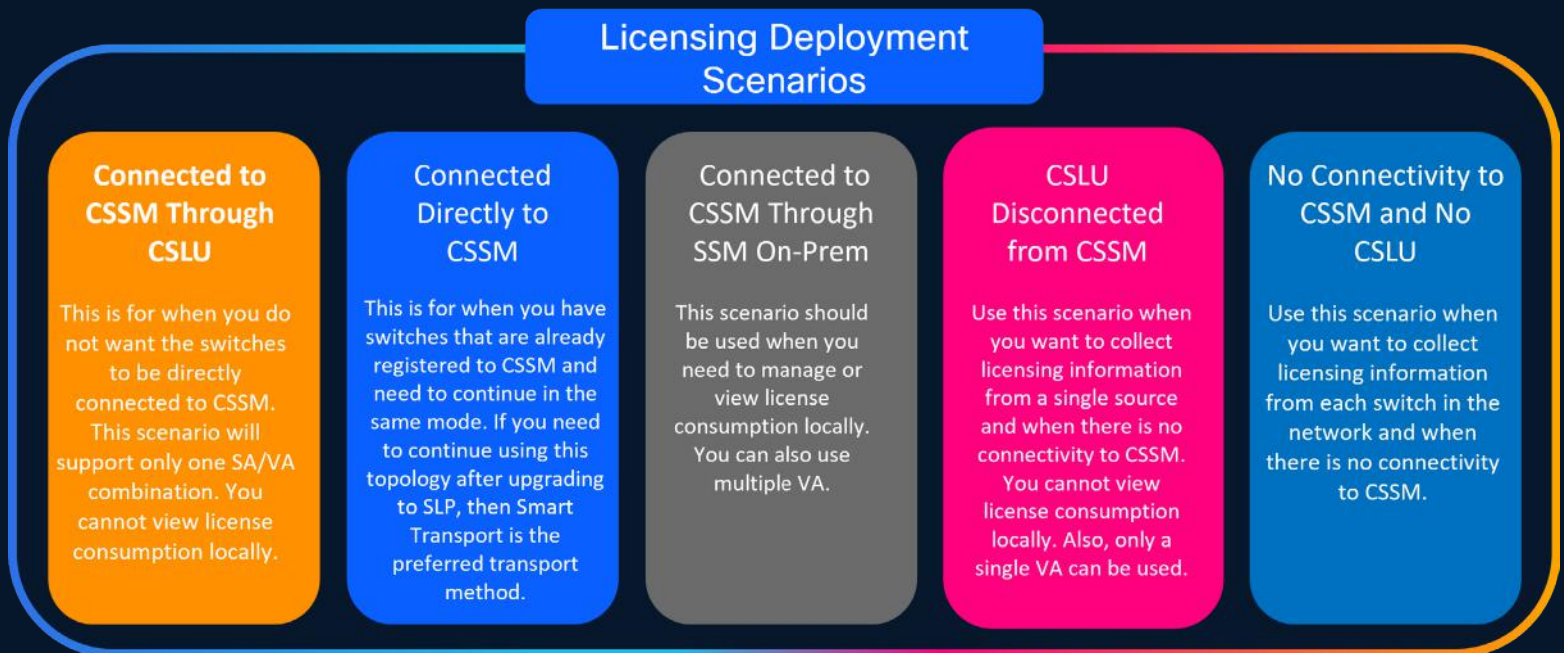
- Is there a CSLU or On-Prem collector available?
- If not, plan for an offline workflow.

[Click here to view our Smart Licensing Guide](#)

Licensing Deployment Scenarios

Different environments call for different licensing setups. Cisco Smart Licensing supports multiple deployment scenarios so you can align with customer security policies, network restrictions, and operational needs.

The infographic below shows the primary options at a glance – from direct cloud connections to fully offline, air-gapped environments.



Select the image for an expanded view.

Supported Scenarios: After Scenario Selection

After a scenario is selected, you can configure the SLP as per the listed procedure. These workflows are only for new deployments. They provide the simplest and fastest way to implement a scenario.

For migrating from an existing licensing model, see Migrating to Smart Licensing Using Policy.

To perform any additional configuration tasks, for instance, to configure a different license, use an add-on license, or to configure a narrower reporting interval, see the Common Tasks for Configuring Smart Licensing Using Policy.

[Click here to view our Smart Licensing Guide](#)

Smart Licensing Scenarios at a Glance

Cisco Smart Licensing can be configured in several ways depending on connectivity and security requirements. Each scenario follows the same core principles but differs in how devices communicate usage to CSSM.

Key Considerations Before You Decide

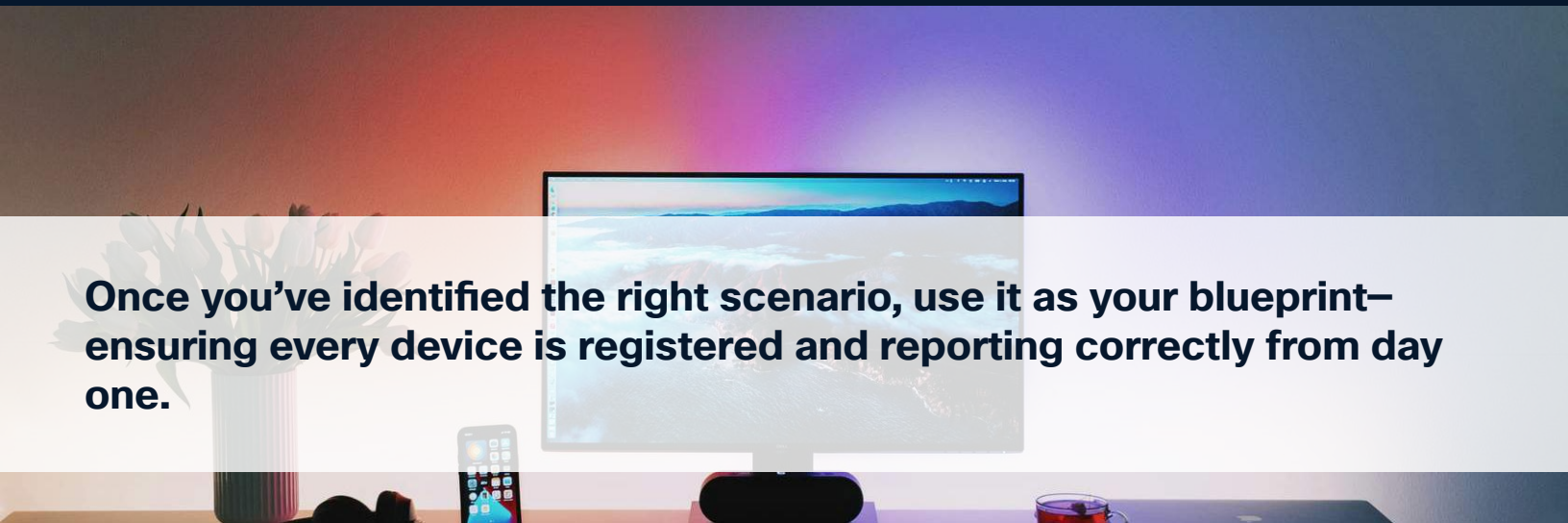
Connectivity	Solution
Devices can reach the internet	Connect Directly to CSSM
Internet blocked, local mediation available	Use CSLU or SSM On-Prem
High-security / air-gapped environment	Use Offline / No Connectivity
Need centralized control across multiple VAs	SSM On-Prem is preferred

How to Choose the Right Scenario

Ask these questions first to confirm the right path:

- Does the environment allow outbound HTTPS?
- Is there an existing CSLU or On-Prem collector?
- Are multiple Virtual Accounts required?
- Does the customer require fully offline licensing?

Tip: The answers to these questions will guide you to the correct scenario and prevent rework later.

A photograph of a desk setup. In the center is a large computer monitor displaying a landscape image. To the left of the monitor is a smartphone on a stand. To the right of the monitor is a small red container. In the foreground, to the left, is a white vase with green leaves. The background is a blurred wall with warm lighting.

Once you've identified the right scenario, use it as your blueprint—ensuring every device is registered and reporting correctly from day one.



Your Path Forward with Smart Licensing

You've explored the foundations of Cisco Smart Licensing—from setting up Smart Accounts and accessing Cisco License Central, to registering assets and selecting the right deployment scenario. Now it's time to put this into action.

Here's your path forward:

Set Up & Access

- Create or request access to a Cisco Smart Account.
- Activate Virtual Accounts if you need to segment by team, project, or site.

Register Assets

- Link devices to Cisco Smart Software Manager (CSSM) using the transport method that best fits your environment—direct cloud, mediated, or offline

Whether you're deploying in a cloud-connected environment or managing fully air-gapped systems, Smart Licensing ensures you have visibility, flexibility, and control over your software investments.

**Cisco Software
Central**

**Smart Licensing
Guide**

**Smart Licensing
Hub**

**Licensing
Support**

Licensing Deployment Scenarios